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The 2028 Grand World Voyage

Holland America Line ms Volendam

129 days · round-trip Fort Lauderdale · January 4 – mid-May 2028



A Voyage Pack from **In the Wake**

Welcome

Made for the cruiser who has booked — or is seriously weighing — Holland America's 2028 Grand World Voyage, and wants one calm, trustworthy read on what a 129-day circumnavigation actually asks of you and gives back.

This pack exists to make one enormous trip easier to hold in your head: **129 days round-trip from Fort Lauderdale aboard ms Volendam**, departing **January 4, 2028** — 45 ports across 26 countries and territories on six continents, a four-day Antarctic Experience, Easter Island, eight days across New Zealand, 65 hours in Cape Town, and a sail past Null Island, the empty patch of ocean where the Equator crosses the Prime Meridian.

A seven-night cruise is a vacation. A world cruise is a season of your life. The planning questions are different in kind, not just in size: visas and vaccinations across hemispheres, a wardrobe that must handle Antarctica and the Equator in the same suitcase set, a home that must run itself for four and a half months, and a budget where the gratuity line alone runs four figures. This pack walks through all of it at the pace the trip deserves.

It is calm by design. There is no urgency, no upsell, no countdown clock. Read it once now, then use it as a working document across the year-plus between booking and embarkation.

The site that produced this pack is independent — no cruise-line affiliations, no shore-excursion commissions, no display ads. Your purchase is the funding model. We do this so you can plan a world cruise from a source that has nothing to gain by talking you into a bigger suite or a longer excursion.

A note on what's first-hand here and what isn't

I haven't sailed this voyage — the 2028 Grand World Voyage hasn't sailed yet for anyone. The ship, port, and logistics content in this pack comes from primary-source research: Holland America's own announcement and published materials for this voyage, registry records for Volendam, the operator's route map, port authorities, consular and government pages, and the port write-ups and firsthand traveler logbook

entries collected on this site. Where a claim can't be sourced, it isn't asserted here — and where a detail is still open (exact per-port timings, which HAL finalizes in your cruise documents), this pack says “approximate” out loud instead of guessing quietly.

Includes an offline-capable Emergency Contacts section — a fillable family handoff card and a consular-contact framework tailored to a six-continent itinerary, available offline after first load via **In the Wake's** PWA companion. Designed to share with one trusted person ashore before sailing — for a voyage this long, that handoff matters more than on any other cruise you've taken.

This pack is written for first-time world cruisers. Most people on a Grand World Voyage have cruised before — often a lot — but almost nobody's first world cruise feels familiar. If you've never cruised at all, read the **first-cruise guide** alongside this; the basics live there so this pack can spend its pages on what makes 129 days different.

At a Glance

Ship	ms Volendam (Rotterdam class, sister ship to Zaandam)
Cruise line	Holland America Line
Specifications	61,214 GT · 10 passenger decks · 1,432 guests (double occupancy) · classic mid-size HAL hull
Year built	1999 (Fincantieri, Italy); Netherlands registry
Voyage	2028 Grand World Voyage — 129 days, round-trip Fort Lauderdale
Departs	January 4, 2028, Port Everglades, Fort Lauderdale
Returns	Mid-May 2028 (confirm the exact date in your cruise documents)

Scope	45 ports · 26 countries and territories · 6 continents · 31 UNESCO World Heritage Sites · 16 Mariners' Collection ports
Signature moments	Four-day Antarctic Experience · Cape Horn & the Beagle Channel · Easter Island · 8 days / 6 ports across New Zealand · 65 hours in Cape Town · four equator crossings · Null Island sail-past (the fourth crossing, exactly at 0°,0°)
Fares (at booking opening)	Interior from ~\$29,999 · Ocean View from ~\$34,499 · Suite from ~\$57,599 per person, double occupancy — pricing is dynamic; verify current fares at hollandamerica.com or with your travel agent
Currency aboard	US Dollar

The route in one paragraph

South from **Fort Lauderdale** through the Caribbean (**San Juan, Barbados**), down the South American coast (Devil's Island, Belém, **Recife, Rio de Janeiro, Montevideo, Buenos Aires**), to the **Falklands** and **Ushuaia** at the bottom of the world; four days along the **Antarctic Peninsula**; back north around **Cape Horn**, through the Strait of Magellan, **Glacier Alley**, and the **Chilean fjords** (**Punta Arenas, Puerto Montt**, San Antonio for Santiago); then the long Pacific — **Easter Island, Pitcairn**, French Polynesia (**Papeete, Moorea, Bora Bora**); eight days across New Zealand (**Auckland, Tauranga**, New Plymouth, **Wellington, Picton, Lyttelton**); up the Australian coast (**Sydney, Brisbane**, Townsville, **Cairns, Darwin**); into Indonesia and Southeast Asia (**Komodo, Bali, Singapore, Phuket**); across the Indian Ocean (**Colombo, Malé, Port Louis**, La Possession on Réunion); around southern Africa (**Durban, Cape Town**, Lüderitz, **Walvis Bay**); up the Gulf of Guinea past Null Island (Takoradi, Abidjan); to Cape Verde (**Praia, Mindelo**); and home across the Atlantic via **San Juan** to Fort Lauderdale.

Port order above follows Holland America's published route map for this voyage. Exact dates, arrival windows, and overnight calls are finalized in your cruise documents and the Navigator app — treat every per-port timing in this pack as

approximate until your final documents say otherwise. Itineraries on a voyage this long also change en route — weather, sea state, and port conditions reroute world cruises most years. Flexibility isn't a caveat on this trip; it's part of the deal.

Section 1 — Your Ship: ms Volendam

A classic mid-size ship, which is the point

Volendam is a **Rotterdam-class** ship delivered by Fincantieri's Marghera yard in 1999 — 61,214 gross tons, ten passenger decks, about 1,432 guests at double occupancy, with Zaandam (2000) as her near-identical sister. Tennis great **Chris Evert** christened her as godmother on November 12, 1999, the same day she sailed her maiden voyage — a Caribbean run out of Fort Lauderdale, which makes the port your 2028 departure shares with her first one. In a fleet era where new ships push past 200,000 tons and 7,000 guests, Volendam is roughly a quarter of that size, and Holland America chose her for this voyage deliberately: a hull this size reaches ports the mega-ships physically cannot — 16 of this itinerary's calls are Mariners' Collection ports (Easter Island, Walvis Bay, Réunion, and Cape Verde among them) that big ships skip.

What "classic HAL" means in practice: a promenade deck that wraps the whole ship, an art and fresh-flower budget instead of a go-kart track, live music over waterslides, and a passenger community that skews toward people who read the daily program and then actually go to the lecture. On a 7-night cruise those qualities are a preference. On a 129-day cruise they're load-bearing — the ship is your home, your town, and your commute, and a calm, well-run mid-size town wears better over four months than a theme park does.

Long-voyage rhythm is Holland America's institutional specialty — the line has operated Grand Voyages for decades, and the crew assignments, enrichment programming, and provisioning for these sailings reflect that. Expect guest lecturers, destination briefings before each region, and the small rituals (equator-crossing ceremony among them — you'll cross twice) that give a long voyage its internal calendar.

Aboard the ship

Grounded in the ship's own venue records on this site, the spaces you'll live in:

- **Dining:** the main Dining Room (the anchor of the evening); **Pinnacle Grill** (HAL's signature steak-and-seafood specialty venue, extra charge); **Canaletto** (Italian, extra charge, tucked alongside the Lido); the **Lido Market** buffet; and the **Explorations Café** for coffee and the best casual reading corner on the ship.
- **Bars and evenings:** the **Crow's Nest** (the forward-facing observation lounge — on this itinerary, the single best interior seat for Glacier Alley, the fjords, and the Antarctic days), the **Ocean Bar**, the **Sea View Bar** aft, the **Explorer's Lounge**, the **Mix Bar**, the **Piano Bar**, the **Wajang Theater**, and the casino.
- **Days at sea:** two pools (**Lido Pool** midships with a sliding glass roof — indispensable across this voyage's climate swings — and the adults-favored **Sea View Pool** aft), the hydropool and hot tubs, the **Greenhouse Spa** and fitness center, a **pickleball / sport court**, an **art studio**, a proper **library**, and a game room. The full walk-around promenade deck deserves its own mention: on a world cruise the daily promenade mile becomes a habit, a social hour, and the trip's best free amenity all at once.

There is no HAL-venue page section on this site yet, so venue names above aren't cross-linked — they're drawn from the ship's venue record and Holland America's own materials. For a video feel of her spaces and the firsthand notes of travelers who've sailed her, the **Volendam ship page** collects both, and the **Ship Size Atlas** puts her 61,214 GT alongside whatever you've sailed before so you can calibrate expectations.

Cabin choice, world-cruise edition

The cabin math changes when the trip is 129 days:

- **You will spend more waking hours in this cabin than in your living room this year.** Storage, light, and a place to sit that isn't the bed matter far more than on a week-long sailing. Book the cabin you can genuinely live in.
- **Ocean View over Interior is a stronger argument here than on any short cruise.** Four-plus months without natural light in your own room is a real quality-of-life cost, and on the scenic days (Antarctica, the fjords, the Beagle Channel)

your window is a private observation post at 6 AM temperatures that make the open deck a commitment.

- **Verandas earn their keep on the tropical legs** — but know going in: on the Antarctic and Southern Ocean days a veranda is mostly a very cold storage locker. If the fare step to a veranda strains the budget, a well-placed Ocean View is the value pick on this particular itinerary.
- **Location:** midships and low remains the most motion-forgiving placement, and this voyage includes the Drake Passage and three ocean crossings (see **Section 7**). If you're motion-sensitive, prioritize placement over floor-plan perks.
- **Laundry:** confirm current laundry arrangements with HAL when you book — on a voyage this length, unlimited laundry packages (frequently bundled or discounted for Grand Voyage guests) change how much you pack. See **Section 4**.

Fares at booking opening started around **\$29,999 per person double occupancy for Interior, ~\$34,499 Ocean View, ~\$57,599 Suite** — dynamic, and moving in one direction as the sailing fills. Early-booking bonuses (onboard credit, air offers) have applied to this voyage; your travel agent or hollandamerica.com has the current picture. **Every dollar figure in this pack is approximate and time-stamped to mid-2026 — reconfirm at booking.**

Section 2 — The Voyage, Leg by Leg

129 days won't fit in a day-by-day table the way a week in Alaska does — and your cruise documents will do that anyway, authoritatively. What this section gives you instead is the voyage the way you'll actually experience it: **eight legs, each with its own climate, rhythm, currency, and planning needs**. Ports with a page on this site are linked — those pages carry the walking-distance detail, traveler logbook entries, and excursion thinking that won't fit here.

A note on timing: day counts below are approximate reconstructions from the published route; treat them as shape, not schedule.

Leg 1 — The Caribbean and the Brazilian coast (roughly days 1–22)

Fort Lauderdale → San Juan → Barbados → Devil’s Island (French Guiana) → Belém → Recife → Rio de Janeiro → Montevideo → Buenos Aires

The voyage opens gently on purpose: familiar Caribbean waters, warm January sun, and enough sea days to find your rhythm — your table, your deck chair, your walking loop, the crew who will know your coffee order by Aruba’s latitude. Use this leg to settle in rather than sprint; the trip will still be there in March.

- **Devil’s Island (Îles du Salut)** is the first “you can’t do this on a normal cruise” stop — the former French penal colony of *Papillon* infamy. **Read the name carefully: you don’t land on Devil’s Island.** Île du Diable itself has no landing and never had one for visitors — prisoners reached it by cable. Ships anchor off and tender to **Île Royale**, the largest of the three islands, which held the general prison population and the administration, and which carries the ruins, the palms, and the agoutis and monkeys that took the place back. Devil’s Island is the small one you photograph across the channel. Tendering is sea-state dependent; if the swell wins, that’s the first lesson in world-cruise flexibility. There is a second, stranger way to lose this call: the islands sit under the launch corridor from Kourou, CNES has owned the archipelago since 1971, and they are **evacuated and closed for every eastward launch** under a prefectural navigation ban — a ban that stays in force through a postponement. A slipped launch window can eat the day.
- **Belém** is the Amazon basin’s great port city — not on the Amazon proper but on the **Pará River at Guajará Bay, roughly 100 km upriver from the Atlantic**, so the approach is a long brown-water river transit rather than a sea arrival. **Expect to tender, and expect to land a long way from the city.** The downtown quay carries little more than seven metres and cannot take a ship of Volendam’s draft; ships anchor off **Icoaraci**, about 18–20 km from the historic centre — Volendam herself did exactly that in January 2026. A new deep berth at Outeiro was built for COP30, but the port authority has said low tide at cruise arrival and departure times makes Outeiro difficult and keeps Icoaraci the more viable option. That may change by 2028; assume the transfer until HAL says otherwise. The **Ver-o-Peso** market has traded since **1625**, when the Casa de Haver o Peso was established (the *Provisão Régia* of 1688 that most sources cite as its founding actually granted the city the market’s revenue, 63 years later). The municipality counts **1,193 licensed traders**

and around 2,400 people working there daily — not the “2,000 stalls” repeated online. Note that the market was physically rebuilt for COP30: fish market September 2025, main fair November 2025, meat market January 2026, so any description written before 2025 is obsolete. **Belém’s Teatro da Paz became a UNESCO World Heritage Site on 27 July 2026** — not alone, but as one of the two components of the serial property *Amazonia Theatres*, with the Teatro Amazonas in Manaus. This is also where the tropics turn serious: equatorial heat and humidity, and the voyage’s **first equator crossing** falls on the run between Devil’s Island and here. If you’ve never been through a shellback ceremony, don’t schedule anything against it.

- **Rio de Janeiro** — the route map marks an extended call here; Rio rewards it. Corcovado and Sugarloaf are the postcard pair, but they’re weather-gated: take the first clear window, not the “scheduled” day.
- **Buenos Aires** closes the leg with another extended call — steak, tango, and the last big-city provisioning stop before Patagonia. Anything you forgot to pack for the cold leg, fix it here.

Practical — the visa item most likely to catch a North American on this leg: Brazil reinstated visa requirements for US, Canadian and Australian citizens on 10 April 2025, and the requirement explicitly covers arrival by vessel. It is an e-Visa, around US\$80.90 at the time of writing, and it is yours to obtain — not something the ship quietly handles. On a voyage whose passenger list is heavily North American this is the single most consequential piece of paperwork in the first month. French Guiana is a different trap in the same leg: it is part of France and of the EU, but it is **not in the Schengen area**, so a Schengen visa does not admit a visa-national — the sticker has to say *Valable pour la Guyane française*. Verify both against HAL’s pre-cruise documentation guidance for this sailing.

January in this leg runs hot — Caribbean low 80s°F, equatorial Brazil hotter — while your suitcase also carries an Antarctic kit you won’t touch for three weeks. Currencies flip fast (US dollar, EC-dollar zones, Brazilian real, Uruguayan and Argentine pesos); cards are broadly fine in the cities, and small-bill US dollars remain the universal tip currency. The **Port Day Planner** earns its keep from the first call, and the **Port Logbook** is worth starting on Day 1 — over 45 ports, memory blurs faster than you think.

Leg 2 — Patagonia and Antarctica (roughly days 23–38)

Port Stanley (Falkland Islands) → Ushuaia → four-day Antarctic Experience → Cape Horn → Beagle Channel & Glacier Alley → Punta Arenas → Strait of Magellan → Sarmiento Channel → Amalia or Brujo Glacier → Chilean fjords → Puerto Montt → San Antonio (for Santiago)

The emotional summit of the voyage, arriving in the Southern Hemisphere's late summer — the only season this route is possible.

- **Port Stanley** is a tender call into a town that feels like a Scottish village misfiled at 51° South; penguin-colony excursions (Gypsy Cove walkable, Volunteer Point the long overland haul) book out — decide early.
- **Ushuaia** — long billed as the southernmost city in the world (Chile's tiny Puerto Williams, granted city status in 2019, now contests the title across the Beagle Channel), gateway to Tierra del Fuego National Park, and the last land before the ice.
- **The four-day Antarctic Experience** is scenic cruising along the **Peninsula** — Volendam does not land passengers in Antarctica; this is expedition-ship territory to see, not to step on, and the plain framing is: four days of the most stupefying scenery on the planet from a warm ship. The Crow's Nest and your cabin window become prime real estate. Wildlife (whales, penguin rafts, seals on floes) appears on its own schedule — keep binoculars within reach at all hours; the announcement from the bridge comes when it comes.
- **Cape Horn** — weather permitting, a sail-past of the most storied headland in maritime history. The Drake Passage earns its reputation in both directions; see **Section 7** and pack accordingly.
- The run north — **Beagle Channel, Glacier Alley, the Strait of Magellan, the Sarmiento Channel, the Amalia/Brujo glacier approach, days of Chilean fjords** — is the longest continuous stretch of scenic cruising on the itinerary. It out-Alaskas Alaska and asks nothing of you but a warm layer and a window seat.
- **San Antonio** is Santiago's port — the gateway to Valparaíso's UNESCO hills, the Casablanca valley wineries, and the capital itself about 1.5 hours inland. If you're hoping family might join you for part of the voyage, a major-city port like this is the natural one to ask about — but **ask HAL, don't assume**: as of mid-2026 Holland America had published no segment or partial-voyage options for this

sailing, and whether any port allows mid-voyage embarkation is the cruise line's call, not a geography question.

Practical: deck temperatures on the Antarctic days sit near freezing with real wind chill; the packing list in **Section 4** treats the glacier kit as a full second wardrobe, and it is not optional. Hand warmers, a genuinely windproof shell, and warm waterproof footwear separate the people on deck for the calving from the people watching through glass.

Leg 3 — The long Pacific (roughly days 39–56)

Easter Island → Pitcairn Island → Papeete → Moorea → Bora Bora

The Pacific is where the voyage changes character. The sea-day stretches get long — this is the leg that teaches you whether you're a world cruiser or just someone on a long cruise, and nearly everyone discovers they're the former. Routines deepen; the lecture series, the library, the promenade miles, and the friendships do the structural work.

- **Easter Island** is the crown jewel and the open gamble of the leg: Rapa Nui is a Mariners' Collection call precisely because almost no cruise ship can visit — and it's an exposed tender operation in open Pacific swell. Ships miss this call some years. If the tender runs, the moai are worth every year you waited; if the swell wins, the ship typically offers a slow sail-past. Hold it loosely — it hurts less that way, and the odds are decent.
- **Pitcairn Island** — home of the Bounty mutineers' descendants, population under fifty. Calls here are typically a slow pass with islanders coming out by longboat; an extraordinary piece of living history either way.
- **French Polynesia** — **Papeete** (with an evening in port marked on the route map), **Moorea's** serrated skyline, and **Bora Bora's** lagoon. Moorea and Bora Bora are tender ports with the South Pacific's best water: snorkel gear from home pays for its suitcase space this week. One quiet map-fact of this leg: from Chile to New Zealand the entire run stays **south** of the equator — the voyage's next crossing waits for the approach to Singapore, three legs away.

Practical: French Polynesia runs on the CFP franc, but cards and (less favorably) US dollars circulate easily in the cruise economy. Late February is cyclone season's tail in the South Pacific — another “flexibility is the deal” region. Sun protection becomes a medical topic: this is equatorial UV over water for weeks.

Leg 4 — New Zealand: eight days, six ports (roughly days 57–64)

Auckland → Tauranga → New Plymouth → Wellington → Picton → Lyttelton (Christchurch)

Eight days, six ports, both islands — the densest port stretch of the entire voyage, deliberately placed after the Pacific's long quiet. New Zealand in early March is late summer: settled, mild, green.

- **Auckland** opens with a city day (route map marks an overnight); **Tauranga** is the gateway to Rotorua's geothermal country and Hobbiton — the two headline excursions compete for the same day, so choose ahead.
- **New Plymouth** is the rarity — a Taranaki-coast call most itineraries skip, with the volcanic cone of Mt. Taranaki behind it on a clear day.
- **Wellington** for Te Papa (one of the world's great free museums), **Picton** for the Marlborough Sounds (and its sauvignon blanc country), **Lyttelton** for Christchurch and the Canterbury plains.

Practical: this stretch is port-a-day intensity after weeks of sea days — pace yourself and pick one thing per port rather than three. NZ dollars, effortless card economy, and the easiest walking-off-the-ship logistics of the whole voyage. Biosecurity is serious here: declare all food, clean your shore shoes, and don't test the beagle at the terminal.

Leg 5 — Australia and Indonesia (roughly days 65–84)

Sydney → Brisbane → Townsville → Cairns → Darwin → Komodo → Bali

- **Sydney** — sailing into Sydney Harbour is one of cruising's canonical arrivals, and the route map marks an overnight: an evening at the Opera House quarter without watching the clock.
- Up the coast: **Brisbane**, then the Queensland reef towns — **Townsville** and **Cairns**, the Great Barrier Reef's front doors. If a reef trip is on your life list, Cairns is the operational base for it; book the marine-park operators early.

- The ship then threads the **Torres Strait** (scenic pilotage waters marked on the route) and crosses the Top End to **Darwin** — tropical-savanna Australia, saltwater-crocodile country, WWII history.
- **Komodo** — a tender call into the national park for the dragons themselves; ranger-escorted walking only, and the rangers mean it. **Bali** closes the leg with temple country and the voyage's re-entry into Asia.

Practical: Australia requires advance electronic travel authority for most nationalities and enforces the same biosecurity seriousness as NZ; Indonesia's entry requirements for cruise passengers are typically handled through the ship — but **verify every visa requirement on this voyage against HAL's pre-cruise documentation guidance, which is authoritative for how *this sailing* is processed** (see **Section 3**). April approaches in Darwin at the top of the wet season's tail: heat, humidity, spectacular thunderheads.

Leg 6 — Southeast Asia and the Indian Ocean (roughly days 85–100)

Singapore → Phuket → Colombo → Malé → Port Louis (Mauritius) → La Possession (Réunion)

- **Singapore** — the run up from Bali brings the voyage's **second equator crossing**, and the ship barely leaves the line's neighborhood while it's here (Singapore sits eighty miles north of it). Marked for an overnight on the route map, and the world's easiest big city for a ship passenger: clean, safe, transit-perfect, food-obsessed. Hawker centers over hotel restaurants, every time. The **third crossing** follows southbound across the Indian Ocean on the long run to Mauritius.
- **Phuket** for Thailand, **Colombo** for Sri Lanka — the route map marks an evening in Colombo, and the temple-and-tea-country day trips are the draw.
- **Malé** — the Maldives call, a tender into the most densely packed small capital on earth, ringed by atoll water that looks color-graded.
- **Port Louis** and **La Possession** — Mauritius and Réunion, the Mascarene pair; Réunion is another Mariners' Collection rarity, a French overseas département whose interior is a UNESCO-listed volcanic amphitheater. Set expectations for the berth: Réunion's cruise call is at **Le Port / Pointe des Galets, a working commercial and container harbour** with limited passenger amenities and nothing

scenic in walking distance — you arrange transport or you stay aboard. If you rent one taxi-for-the-day on this leg, Réunion’s cirque viewpoints are where to spend it.

Practical: this is the leg with the widest currency spread of the trip (Singapore and Brunei dollars won’t be confused, but rupees, rufiyaa, Mauritian rupees, and euros on Réunion all rotate through in two weeks) — the card-plus-small-USD strategy carries it. It’s also the leg to mind the heat with intention: equatorial Asia in April is the hottest sustained stretch of the voyage.

Leg 7 — Southern and West Africa (roughly days 101–117)

Durban → Cape Town (65 hours) → Lüderitz → Walvis Bay → Null Island sail-past → Takoradi (Ghana) → Abidjan (Côte d’Ivoire)

- **Durban** opens South Africa; some guests use the Durban–Cape Town gap for HAL’s multi-day overland safari add-on — if a Big Five reserve is on your list, this is the voyage’s built-in window for it.
- **Cape Town** gets **65 hours** — the longest single call of the voyage, and it needs every one: Table Mountain (cableway is wind-gated; take the first clear morning), the Cape Peninsula loop to the Cape of Good Hope, the winelands, Robben Island (book weeks ahead), and the V&A Waterfront on the doorstep of the berth.
- **Lüderitz** — a German-colonial time capsule wedged between the Namib dunes and the South Atlantic. **A tender call:** the ship anchors in Robert Harbour and tenders to the waterfront jetty, from which the little town is walkable; the sand-filled ghost town of **Kolmanskop is about 10 km inland**, a half-day with a local operator (they meet the pier). **Walvis Bay** — flamingo lagoons and the dune sea, another Mariners’ Collection call, and a docked one.
- **Null Island** — the ship then arcs north across the Gulf of Guinea to **0°N, 0°E**, the point where the Equator meets the Prime Meridian — the voyage’s **fourth and final equator crossing**, made exactly at the null point. There is nothing there but a weather buoy and every mis-geocoded data point on earth, which is precisely the charm. Expect the bridge to make a ceremony of it; positional bragging rights don’t get purer.
- **Takoradi** and **Abidjan** — Ghana and Côte d’Ivoire, West African calls that almost no itinerary makes. From Takoradi, **Cape Coast Castle and Elmina Castle** — **both UNESCO World Heritage Sites** — sit about 81 km east, roughly 1½

hours each way, which makes them a full-day commitment rather than the quick hop “nearby” would suggest. They carry the Atlantic slave trade’s heaviest history and deserve the gravity the sites ask; budget the whole day and go quiet rather than pairing them with anything else.

Practical: this is the leg where health-prep done a year earlier pays off — parts of coastal West Africa carry **yellow fever and malaria considerations that are medical decisions, not packing decisions: consult a travel-medicine clinic well before sailing** (see **Section 3**). South Africa and Namibia are straightforward card economies; Ghana and Côte d’Ivoire are cash-friendlier — the ship’s shore-excursion desk smooths most of it.

Leg 8 — Cape Verde and the Atlantic home (roughly days 118–129)

Praia → Mindelo → Atlantic crossing → San Juan → Fort Lauderdale

Cape Verde — **Praia** and **Mindelo**, morna music and Creole-Portuguese island culture, the final Mariners’ Collection calls — and then the long Atlantic run home with a last warm evening in **San Juan** before Port Everglades.

The crossing days at the end aren’t filler; ask anyone who’s done a Grand Voyage. They’re the decompression chamber — the packing, the address-swapping, the crew farewells, the first serious attempt to answer “so how was it?” Fair warning from every world-cruise memoir ever written: the answer takes longer than the crossing.

Section 3 — The Pre-Cruise Year

A world cruise’s countdown starts a year out, and the early items are the ones that can’t be compressed. The **countdown tool** generates date-pegged reminders once your sailing is loaded; here is the world-cruise-specific staging.

12+ months out — the structural decisions

- **Book, and choose the cabin you can live in** (Section 1's calculus). Grand Voyages sell on a different curve than regular sailings — the best cabins go to past Grand Voyage guests early.
- **Passport first, everything else second.** It must be valid **at least six months beyond mid-May 2028** — practically, into 2029 — with a generous supply of blank pages for six continents of stamps. If renewal is anywhere on the horizon, do it now; every visa below keys off the passport you'll carry.
- **Travel insurance, treated as a medical decision.** On a 129-day, six-continent voyage with Antarctic waters and long open-ocean stretches, **medical evacuation coverage is the line item that matters** — evacuation from southern Chile or mid-Pacific is a five-to-six-figure event uninsured. Buy within your policy's early-purchase window (often 14–21 days from deposit) if you want pre-existing-condition waivers. Read the per-trip duration cap — many off-the-shelf policies stop at 90 days, which quietly disqualifies them for this voyage; Grand Voyage guests usually need a specialist or annual policy.
- **Travel-medicine clinic consult.** Bring the full port list. Yellow fever vaccination (with the certificate), malaria prophylaxis decisions for the West African calls, routine-vaccine currency, and a personal medical kit sized for four months are clinical calls to make with a professional a year out — some vaccines need lead time. This pack deliberately does not give medical advice beyond: go, early, with the itinerary in hand.
- **Start the visa file.** Requirements depend on your nationality and change; **HAL's pre-cruise documentation guidance for this specific voyage is the authoritative checklist** — cruise lines arrange group handling for several countries and tell you exactly which ones you must secure yourself (Australia's electronic authority is the classic self-serve item for US passport holders). Build the file early; a couple of visas involve mailing your actual passport somewhere.

9 months out — the house that runs itself

Four and a half months is past the point where a neighbor with a key covers it. The checklist that works:

- **Money on autopilot:** every recurring bill to autopay; two credit cards with no foreign transaction fee (carried in separate bags); your bank told the truth about where you'll be; a trusted person with (formal, written — consider a limited power of attorney) authority to handle the truly unexpected.
- **Mail:** USPS forwarding to your trusted person or a mail service that scans. Pause every subscription box now, not in December.
- **Prescriptions:** most US insurers won't fill 130 days at once without a **vacation override** — start that fight (usually winnable, but slow) with your insurer and prescriber months out. Carry all medication in original labeled containers, in carry-on, with a doctor's letter for anything controlled — several countries on this route (notably in Asia) regulate medications you may consider routine; check each against the itinerary or ask the travel-medicine clinic while you're there.
- **The house itself:** someone lays eyes on it weekly (insurance policies often require it for long vacancies — read yours); heating set for a Northern winter you won't attend; car on a battery tender or formally stored; plants rehomed with proper goodbyes.

6 months out — commitments

- **Final payment** (Grand Voyage payment schedules differ from standard sailings — the dates are in your booking confirmation; calendar them the day you book).
- **Book the life-list excursions that sell out:** the South Africa overland safari add-on, Robben Island, reef operators in Cairns, Falklands penguin colonies. Ship excursions vs. independent operators follows the usual math (ship costs more, waits for you; independent costs less, doesn't) — but on a world cruise, the ship-waits-for-you insurance is worth more at the remote tender ports than it ever is on a Caribbean week.
- **Flights and pre-cruise hotel:** into Fort Lauderdale **the day before** at minimum — January 3 at the latest for a January 4 sailing. Missing a 7-night cruise costs a vacation; missing this one costs a season. Book refundable where you can.

3 months out — paperwork convergence

- Online check-in when it opens; print the boarding documents anyway (six continents teach you: paper doesn't run out of battery).
- Confirm every visa is physically in the passport or electronically confirmed against the passport number, and that the yellow-fever certificate travels with the passport, not the checked bag.
- Photograph/scan everything — passport, visas, insurance cards, prescriptions, credit cards front and back — into a folder your at-home contact also holds (**Section 6**).

The final month

- Pack from **Section 4**'s list, early enough to discover what you don't own yet.
 - Do the handoff card in **Section 6** with your at-home contact, out loud, both of you holding a copy.
 - Say your goodbyes with more slack than a normal vacation — you'll be unreachable-ish for stretches, and four months is long enough that life at home will move while you're gone. That's not a warning, just the truth of the thing.
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Section 4 — Packing for Four Seasons in One Trip

The 129-day packing problem decomposes into one insight: **you're not packing for a trip, you're outfitting a small life** — one with an Antarctic fortnight, an equatorial spring, two temperate autumns, and a couple dozen formal-adjacent evenings. Three principles carry it:

1. **Layers beat garments.** The same merino base + fleece + shell system that handles a 30°F Antarctic deck disassembles into pieces you'll wear separately in Wellington and never in Singapore.

2. **The laundry service is part of your wardrobe.** With onboard laundry (confirm the current Grand Voyage laundry arrangements when booking — packages are frequently part of the deal), you need roughly 10–12 days of clothing, not 129. Pack for two weeks; wash forever.
3. **Buy en route, deliberately.** Buenos Aires, Sydney, Singapore, and Cape Town are first-rate resupply stops. What you can't buy en route: your prescription glasses, your medications, your broken-in shoes, and anything that fits you specifically. Those get priority in the suitcase; commodity t-shirts don't.

Documents and money

- Passport (valid into 2029, blank pages plentiful) + **paper photocopies stored separately** + digital scans with your at-home contact.
- Yellow-fever certificate stapled mentally to the passport; visa confirmations printed.
- Two no-foreign-fee credit cards, one debit/ATM card, carried in separate bags; ~\$300–400 in small-bill USD for tips and cash-first ports (replenishable at sea and in card-economy ports).
- Insurance cards (medical + evacuation policy numbers), vaccination record, prescription letters.

Carry-on (never checked, ever)

All medications (full supply — see **Section 3**) · glasses/spares · passport & document file · electronics and chargers · one full change of clothes · anything irreplaceable. Checked bags have 129 days to catch up with you; your blood-pressure medication doesn't.

The cold kit (Antarctica, Patagonia, Cape Horn — used ~2½ weeks, worth every liter of suitcase)

- Thermal base layers (2 sets, merino or synthetic — cotton stays home).
- Mid-layer fleece or down sweater; a true **windproof, waterproof shell** — the single most important garment on the voyage.

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- Warm hat, gloves (liner + insulated), scarf/buff, warm socks (several), waterproof insulated footwear with grip for wet decks.
 - **Air-activated hand warmers, a full box** — hours of static glacier-watching is exactly their use case.
 - Binoculars (8x42 or 10x42) — arguably a cold-kit item; you'll use them from the Falklands to the fjords daily.

The warm kit (used ~14 of 18 weeks)

- 10–12 days of hot-weather rotation: breathable shirts, shorts/skirts, 2 swimsuits, sun hat with a chin strap (tender rides eat hats), polarized sunglasses.
- **Sun protection as a system:** reef-safe SPF 50 (several bottles — it's pricey aboard and in Polynesia), long-sleeve sun shirts, lip SPF. The equatorial-UV-over-water weeks are a dermatological event.
- Insect repellent (DEET or picaridin) for the tropical and West African calls — pairs with the malaria conversation from your travel-medicine consult.
- Comfortable broken-in walking shoes + sandals + water shoes (tender-beach landings and reef shallows).
- Light rain shell for the tropics (the cold-kit shell is too warm at 5° latitude).

Evenings

HAL's evening culture on Grand Voyages keeps a dressier floor than a Caribbean week: **smart casual most nights, with a formal-leaning “Dressy Night” cadence that adds up over 18 weeks** (figure a couple dozen across the voyage — the exact rhythm is in your documents). One or two genuinely dressy outfits, re-worn without apology — everyone does — plus mix-and-match separates carry it. A packable garment bag earns its space; a tuxedo is optional and increasingly rare, but on a world cruise you won't feel silly owning the night either.

The small-life items

- Power: a USB multi-port charging cube (surge-protected power strips are banned aboard, fleet-standard), plus plug adapters — this route touches US, EU, UK/South

African, and Australian/NZ socket types; one good universal adapter beats four singles.

- A journal, and the discipline to use it — 45 ports blur; every Grand Voyage veteran says the journal is the thing they'd never skip twice. (The **Port Logbook** is the digital version; use either, use something.)
- E-reader loaded deep; the ship's library is good but 129 days is a lot of reading.
- Magnetic hooks (cabin walls are steel), packing cubes, a folding day-pack for ports, a travel mug, a small umbrella (tropics) — and see the **cabin organization guide** for making 200 square feet work as a four-month home.
- Snorkel set if the Polynesia/reef legs matter to you — rental exists, but your own mask that fits is the difference.

Skip

Iron (banned; pressing service exists) · surge-protected strips (banned) · hair dryer (provided) · 129 days of clothes (the laundry is the wardrobe) · anything you're carrying for a hypothetical formal emergency that two dressy outfits don't already cover.

Section 5 — Budget: the whole world-cruise math

The fare is the headline, but a 129-day budget has five more lines that deserve daylight. **All figures approximate, stamped mid-2026, dynamic in both directions — verify at booking.** The **cruise budget calculator** turns this framework into your numbers.

The framework (per person, double occupancy)

Line	Realistic range	Notes
Fare	from ~\$29,999 (Interior) / ~\$34,499 (Ocean View) / ~\$57,599 (Suite)	Booking-opening levels; early-booking bonuses (onboard credit, air) offset meaningfully
Crew Appreciation	\$2,322 (standard: \$18/day × 129) · \$2,580 (suite: \$20/day)	HAL's current daily rates, effective mid-2026 — rates adjust roughly annually; reconfirm at booking. Adjustable aboard at Guest Services
Shore excursions	\$2,000–6,000+	The widest-variance line. 45 ports × ship-excursion averages lands mid-range; independent walking days at half the calls pulls it down; the safari add-on, helicopters, and Antarctica-adjacent splurges push it up
Bar / specialty dining / spa	\$1,000–4,000	A drink package priced across 129 days is a serious commitment — do per-day math against your true consumption (drink calculator) before committing; pay-as-you-go with wine-package economics suits most Grand Voyage drinkers
Internet	\$500–1,500	Voyage-length packages price far better per-day than weekly rates; see Section 8

Line	Realistic range	Notes
Visas, vaccines, insurance	\$1,500–4,000+	Travel-medicine consult + vaccines (yellow fever isn't cheap), visa fees across the file, and the evacuation-grade insurance policy — age-sensitive, sometimes steeply
Port-day cash, laundry extras, gifts, misc.	\$1,500–3,000	~\$30–60/port day average covers lunch, transit, small purchases across 45 ports

The all-in picture: for two people in an Ocean View, all-in — fare, tips, mid-range excursions, moderate bar, insurance, the works — plan around **\$85,000–100,000 per couple**, with disciplined-independent travelers coming in under and safari-and-suite travelers well over. Per day per person that's roughly **\$330–390** — which, measured against 129 days of housing, food, transportation, entertainment, and six continents, is the quiet arithmetic that convinces people world cruises are not as irrational as the sticker suggests.

Where the money is decided

1. **Cabin category** — the fare gap between Interior and Suite is the price of a car; every other line is rounding error next to it.
2. **Excursion philosophy** — 45 ship excursions vs. 45 researched walking days is a five-figure swing per couple. The middle path: ship excursions at the remote/tender/high-stakes calls (where the ship-waits-for-you insurance is worth real money), independent in the easy card-economy cities (NZ, Australia, Singapore, Cape Town).
3. **The drink package decision, made with a calculator, not at embarkation.**

Onboard credit is real money on a Grand Voyage — booking bonuses on this voyage have run to four figures per stateroom; treat it as the excursion budget's first installment.

Section 6 — Emergency Contacts

Every Voyage Pack ships with this section, and on a 129-day voyage it's the load-bearing one. Fill in the handoff card, share it with one trusted person ashore, and walk them through it out loud before you sail. This section — with the card — is available offline in the **PWA companion** after first load, so your person ashore can keep it on a phone that works without signal.

The family handoff card

FAMILY HANDOFF – IN THE WAKE VOYAGE PACK

CRUISER: _____
 CABIN: _____
 SHIP: ms Volendam
 LINE: Holland America Line
 VOYAGE: 2028 Grand World Voyage
 SAILING: Jan 4 – mid-May 2028 (129 days)
 FROM/TO: Port Everglades, Fort Lauderdale, FL (round-trip)

ROUTE (by leg):

Jan: Caribbean → Brazil → Uruguay → Argentina
 Feb: Falklands → Ushuaia → ANTARCTICA (4 days, scenic)
 → Chilean fjords → Chile → Easter Island →
 French Polynesia
 Mar: New Zealand → Australia
 Apr: Indonesia → Singapore → Thailand → Sri Lanka →
 Maldives → Mauritius/Réunion → South Africa
 May: Namibia → West Africa → Cape Verde → San Juan → home

HOLLAND AMERICA LINE (per HAL's emergency FAQ):

Business hours (Pacific):
 +1 (800) 426-0327
 After hours & holidays:
 +1 (800) 628-4771
 Critical emergencies only:
 +1 (206) 626-7382
 (Numbers move – verify against your booking
 confirmation when it arrives and correct here
 if needed: _____)

U.S. STATE DEPARTMENT (24/7, any country):

From the US: +1 (888) 407-4747
 From abroad: +1 (202) 501-4444
 Per-country embassy list: travel.state.gov

CRUISER MEDICAL:

Allergies: _____
 Medications: _____
 Conditions: _____
 Insurance: _____ policy: _____
 Evac policy: _____ policy: _____

MOST RECENT KNOWN POSITION:

Track at: </tools/ship-tracker.html>
 or marinetraffic.com (search "Volendam")

What an at-home contact does

1. **Recalibrate the silence math.** On a Caribbean cruise, 36 quiet hours might mean something. On this voyage, the Antarctic days, the Pacific crossings, and long Indian Ocean stretches make **multi-day quiet completely normal**. Agree on the rhythm before sailing — e.g., “a message every port day, and don’t worry between them” — and write the current leg’s expectations down.
2. **Ship first, embassies second.** For a genuine emergency at home that the cruiser needs to know about, Holland America’s emergency lines — **+1 (800) 426-0327** during Pacific business hours, **+1 (800) 628-4771** after hours and holidays, per HAL’s own travel-emergency FAQ (verify against your booking paperwork, since numbers move) — can reach the ship anywhere on earth, at sea included. Between them the coverage is around-the-clock; that’s the front door.
3. **For an emergency involving the cruiser abroad**, the U.S. State Department numbers above run 24/7 and route to the right embassy or consulate for whichever of the 26 countries the ship is in — that’s exactly what those numbers are for, and why this card doesn’t try to list two dozen embassy phone numbers that go stale. (The cruiser should also enroll in **STEP** — the Smart Traveler Enrollment Program, step.state.gov — before sailing; it registers the whole itinerary with the relevant posts.)
4. **Track the ship for context, not anxiety** — link on the card.

The cruiser’s own emergency kit

- Paper photocopy of passport + visas, separate from the passport; digital scans held by your at-home contact.
 - Insurance and **medical-evacuation policy numbers in your wallet**, not just in an email.
 - Printed medication list with generic names (brand names don’t cross borders well).
 - The ship’s daily program lists the onboard medical center’s hours — on a voyage this long, introduce yourself early rather than at 2 AM in week nine; the center handles chronic-care continuity (dressings, B12 shots, INR checks) routinely on Grand Voyages, and knowing the drill beats discovering it.
-

Section 7 — Seasickness and the Open-Ocean Legs

The plain map of where this voyage can move under you:

- **The Drake Passage / Cape Horn waters (twice through the region)** — the most famous rough water on earth, and the reputation is earned. Late-summer crossings are frequently gentle (“Drake Lake”) and occasionally the other thing. The ship’s routing gives the Peninsula’s sheltered side its four days, but the approach and Cape Horn segments are open Southern Ocean.
- **The long Pacific** (Chile → Easter Island → Polynesia) — mostly benign trade-wind seas, but it’s weeks of open ocean; long-period swell is a lifestyle, not an event.
- **The Tasman approach to New Zealand and the Australian Bight-adjacent legs** — capable of a proper blow in March.
- **The Indian Ocean crossing** (Maldives → Mascarenes → Durban) — including the Agulhas current region off South Africa, respected water in any season.
- **The Atlantic home** — May trade-wind crossing, usually the gentlest of the lot.

Two framings belong together: first, **a 61,000-ton ship is a solid, modern-stabilized hull, but no ship makes the Drake Passage disappear** — tonnage is not a promise about motion, and anyone who tells you otherwise hasn’t crossed it. Second, most world-cruise veterans report the opposite surprise: week after week of open ocean that’s simply... fine, with one or two stories they dine out on afterward. Both are true; pack for the second story.

The kit (pharmacology unchanged from every pack we write, because it works): **meclizine** (Bonine / Less-Drowsy Dramamine) taken an hour *before* expected motion; **scopolamine patches** by prescription for known severe sufferers — on this voyage, worth the doctor conversation for the Drake days specifically; ginger and Sea-Bands for the mild end; and the behavioral basics — mid-ship low placement, horizon time on deck, dry crackers, skip the alcohol on the rough nights. The full evidence rundown lives at **what actually works for seasickness**.

If you're motion-sensitive enough that this section worries you: choose the cabin location first (**Section 1**), get the patch prescription second, and then book — thousands of motion-sensitive cruisers have done this exact voyage happily on exactly that plan.

Section 8 — Practical Logistics for 129 Days

The Navigator app, and the ship's daily rhythm

Holland America's **Navigator app** carries the daily program, deck plans, account, and shipboard messaging. On a Grand Voyage the printed daily program (delivered to the cabin nightly) is still the cultural artifact — the lecture schedule, the destination briefings, the dance-hosts calendar, the leg-by-leg rituals. Read it with the evening's coffee; it's the town newspaper of your floating town.

Staying connected across six continents

- **Ship Wi-Fi:** buy the voyage-length package, not weekly increments — per-day pricing drops dramatically at Grand Voyage length (budget line in **Section 5**). Modern HAL connectivity handles email, messaging, photos, and video calls in most waters; expect degradation in the far south and mid-ocean, and treat that as part of the experience rather than an outage.
- **Cellular:** 26 countries of roaming charges is a bill nobody needs. The working pattern: phone on airplane mode at sea as default; an eSIM data plan (regional or global) for the port-intensive legs; Wi-Fi calling for voice. **Never let the phone roam onto the ship's maritime cellular network** — that's the \$3-a-minute mistake, on every line, every ship.
- **Time zones:** you'll cross roughly two dozen boundaries **plus the International Date Line westbound** — **somewhere in the Pacific you will go to bed on one date and wake up two dates later, having donated a day of your life to the calendar gods** (you get it back in change, an hour at a time, all the way home). The

ship announces every change the night before; the seasoned move is changing your watch at the announcement, not at midnight.

Money across ~20 currencies

The strategy that survives contact with six continents: **cards everywhere they work** (NZ, Australia, Singapore, South Africa, and the cities — which is most of the spend), **small-bill USD as the universal fallback** (tips, tenders, markets, West Africa), and **local cash withdrawn sparingly** at bank ATMs in the card-hostile stops rather than exchanged in bulk. Two no-foreign-fee cards in separate bags (**Section 4**); the shipboard account settles in USD.

Laundry, mail, and the small systems

- **Laundry:** the wardrobe multiplier (**Section 4**) — confirm the Grand Voyage laundry arrangement at booking and use it without rationing.
- **Mail and packages:** yes, you can receive mail — HAL publishes port-agent addresses for Grand Voyage mail drops in the cruise documents; birthday cards from grandchildren really do arrive in Sydney. Have your at-home contact use only the official port-agent process, with lead time.
- **Celebrations:** 129 days contains birthdays, anniversaries, and at least one holiday you care about. Tell your travel agent / ship's staff in advance; Grand Voyage crews are famously good to the guests whose milestones they're keeping.
- **The community:** world cruises develop a society — trivia teams with four-month arcs, the promenade walking club, the Crow's Nest regulars, table families. The single most consistent report from Grand Voyage veterans: the ports were extraordinary and *the people are what they miss*. Come willing to be a regular somewhere.

When plans change (they will)

Over 129 days, expect at least one skipped or substituted port (swell at a tender call, port congestion, weather routing), at least one itinerary-order shuffle, and schedule slides measured in hours. The contract every world cruiser makes with the trip: **the route map is a plan, the ocean gets a vote, and the ship's daily program is the**

truth. Compensation practices for missed ports (port-fee refunds, sometimes credit) are handled aboard; the emotional practice — holding Easter Island loosely — is handled by you, starting now.

Section 9 — Accessibility Notes

A clear-eyed accessibility read on this specific voyage, because it differs from a modern-megaship week in ways that matter:

- **Volendam is a 1999-built ship.** Accessible staterooms exist in limited number and book earliest of all — if you need one, that’s a book-at-announcement item, arranged directly with HAL’s accessibility desk (they’re good; use them). Elevators cover the passenger decks; the promenade and main venues are wheelchair-navigable.
- **This itinerary is tender-heavy.** Devil’s Island (landing on Île Royale), Port Stanley, Easter Island, Moorea, Bora Bora, Komodo, Malé, Lüderitz, and others are tender or potentially-tender calls — and tender transfers in swell carry mobility requirements the ship’s staff will assess conditions-day for everyone’s safety. Wheelchair users and limited-mobility cruisers should plan the tender ports as “ship-day if conditions say so” and weight the docked calls (the cities, NZ, Australia, Singapore, Cape Town) as the excursion anchors — which happens to be where the accessible-infrastructure excursions are anyway.
- **The scenic days are fully accessible** — Antarctica, Glacier Alley, the fjords, Cape Horn, and Null Island ask nothing but a window or a deck rail, and they’re the itinerary’s crown jewels. The Crow’s Nest is the sheltered accessible viewpoint.
- **Port infrastructure varies by two centuries across this route** — Wellington’s flat waterfront and Takoradi’s working harbor are different planets. HAL’s shore-excursion desk marks accessible tours per port; independent accessibility research per call is worth doing for the handful of ports you care most about.
- **Medical continuity:** the onboard medical center handles chronic-care continuity routinely on Grand Voyages (**Section 6**); oxygen, dialysis, and similar needs

require advance arrangement with HAL — start those conversations at booking, not at the pier.

The site's broader **disability-at-sea guide** covers cross-line practice in more depth.

Section 10 — Solo Traveler Notes

World cruises are quietly one of the best solo-travel formats that exists: a built-in community with four months to become lasting friendships, structured social scaffolding (shared tables, trivia, dance hosts, the promenade society), and the safety envelope of the ship wrapped around six continents of solo exploration.

The math and the practical notes:

- **The single supplement is the obstacle.** HAL's standard supplement runs to the familiar ~200% baseline, with Grand Voyages occasionally offering reduced-supplement promotions — on a fare this size the difference is enormous, so **ask your travel agent to watch for solo promotions the way other people watch airfares.** Volendam has no dedicated solo-cabin category; the play is a modest Interior or Ocean View at the best supplement you can catch.
 - **Shared main-dining tables are the solo world-cruiser's institution** — say yes to the large table for the first leg; you can always renegotiate after you know everyone.
 - The rhythm favors solos: enrichment lectures, the library, port walking, the walking club — none of it requires a plus-one, and the four-month arc means you'll stop being "the solo traveler" and start being *you* by about Buenos Aires.
 - Safety ashore follows the standard solo playbook (well-trafficked areas, the buddy system with your new table family at the cash-economy ports, a photo of your passport in the cloud) — the **solo cruising hub** and **practical guide** carry the full doctrine.
-

Section 11 — First World Cruise Notes

Things the brochures don't say, offered calmly:

There is a wall, and it's usually around week six or seven. Somewhere in the long Pacific, the novelty engine runs down and a strange flatness arrives — every Grand Voyage veteran describes it, few brochures do. It passes, typically the moment the next port delivers something unplanned. Knowing it's normal is most of the cure. Pace yourself before it: you cannot do every lecture, every port, every evening in month one and still have a self left for month three.

Budget your energy like money. The port-a-day New Zealand leg after the empty Pacific is glorious and exhausting by design. A deliberate ship-day in a port you "should" explore is not a failure; by April it's wisdom.

The journal is not optional. Forty-five ports produce a specific cruel arithmetic: by Cape Town you will not remember Recife without notes. Ten minutes a night. You'll thank this paragraph in 2029.

Your relationship with home changes shape. Four months is long enough for life at home to move — babies arrive, jobs change, seasons turn without you. The weekly call/message rhythm you set in **Section 6** isn't just emergency plumbing; it's how you stay woven in. Budget internet accordingly, and grace likewise.

Re-entry is its own leg of the voyage. The consistent report: coming home is stranger than leaving. The house is exactly where you left it and you are not. Give yourself a soft week before resuming full-speed life, and expect "how was it?" to be unanswerable at dinner-party length — that's what the journal, the photos, and the friendships you'll keep from the ship are for.

And the thing everyone asks: yes — people do this more than once. The repeat rate on Grand Voyages tells you what you need to know about how the story usually ends.

If this is your first cruise entirely, read the **first-cruise guide** for the basics this pack skipped; if you're deciding between this and smaller trips first — the advice most world cruisers give is that they wish they'd gone sooner.

Continue planning on the site

- **Your ship:** the **Volendam profile** — photos, video, deck plans link, and traveler logbook entries; her scale in context in the **Ship Size Atlas**; her live position year-round in the **Ship Logbook**.
- **Your ports:** most of this itinerary's calls have full pages with walking notes, weather patterns, and firsthand logbook entries — start from the leg-by-leg links in **Section 2**, or browse all **388 ports**.
- **Your tools:** **countdown** · **packing lists** · **budget calculator** · **drink calculator** · **tipping calculator** · **port day planner** · **port logbook**.
- **The PWA companion for this voyage** — the day-by-day route, destination weather normals, live forecasts as each call approaches, and the offline Emergency Contacts card: **volendam-world-2028**. Save it to your phone before you sail; it works at sea without signal.
- **Other Voyage Packs:** the **full catalog**.

Share or save. The HTML version of this pack has a floating share bar (lower-right on desktop) — copy a link, ping a friend on WhatsApp, or generate a QR code if you're showing someone the page in person. If a tablemate on the voyage wants their own copy, pointing them at the catalog keeps the lights on here.

Closing

A world cruise is the rare purchase where the cliché is simply accurate: you are not buying a trip, you're buying a season of your one life and spending it on the whole planet at once. The ship is small and calm on purpose. The route is long and strange on purpose — penal-colony ruins and penguin colonies, the moai and the mutineers' island, a city you can't drive to and an island that exists mostly as a coordinate joke, sixty-five hours under Table Mountain and four days along the ice.

The pack you've just read is meant to carry the planning weight so the year between now and January 2028 can be spent looking forward to it rather than bracing for it.

A few things worth remembering as the date approaches:

- **The passport and the medical consult are the two items that can't be rushed.**
Do them first.
- **Book the cabin you can live in; the window is worth more here than on any other cruise.**
- **Pack half the clothes and twice the sun protection; the laundry is the wardrobe.**
- **Hold the tender ports loosely — especially the famous one.**
- **Start the journal on Day 1.**

If you want a one-line preflight reminder to yourself: **the goal is calm.** The ship will handle the miles. Your job is to be rested enough, prepared enough, and unhurried enough to be present for all 129 days of it.

Soli Deo Gloria.

Pack version	v0.1.17 (hal-volendam-world-cruise-2028)
Sailing	ms Volendam, 2028 Grand World Voyage — 129 days round-trip Fort Lauderdale, departing January 4, 2028
Audience	First-time world cruisers, any background
Last reviewed	2026-07-30
How facts here are checked	Every ship spec, date, port, fare, and rate in this pack is checked against a primary or authoritative source — Holland America's own 2028 Grand Voyages announcement and route map, the Volendam profile and registry data on this site, HAL's published Crew Appreciation FAQ, U.S. State Department consular resources, and agency-published booking- opening fares. Per-port timings are marked approximate because HAL finalizes them in cruise documents. Sources for each claim live in this pack's factcheck sidecar. If a number can't be sourced, it isn't asserted here.

Accessibility	This pack and the site that produced it follow WCAG 2.1 AA. The Emergency Contacts section is offline-capable via the PWA companion so a trusted contact ashore can keep the family handoff card available without an internet connection. See also disability-at-sea .
Sources	Ship: Volendam ; scale via Ship Size Atlas . Ports (site pages): San Juan, Barbados, Recife, Rio de Janeiro, Montevideo, Buenos Aires, Ushuaia, Punta Arenas, Puerto Montt, Easter Island, Papeete, Moorea, Bora Bora, Auckland, Tauranga, Wellington, Picton, Lyttelton, Sydney, Brisbane, Cairns, Darwin, Komodo, Bali, Singapore, Phuket, Colombo, Durban, Cape Town, Walvis Bay, Praia, Mindelo, San Juan — linked at first mention in Section 2. Articles: cruise-seasickness-what-works , cruise-cabin-organization . Tools: countdown , packing-lists , cruise-budget-calculator , drink-calculator , cruise-tipping-calculator , port-day-planner , port-tracker , ship-tracker . Reference: first-cruise , solo hub , internet-at-sea , disability-at-sea . Original research: hollandamerica.com 2028 Grand Voyages announcement (April 2026) and route map; HAL Crew Appreciation FAQ; travel.state.gov; U.S. Consulate/State Department contact pages; agency booking-opening fare listings (mid-2026). Cover image: Volendam at Porto do Funchal by Dietmar Rabich, CC BY-SA 4.0, Wikimedia Commons.
Pricing reminder	Pricing in this document is approximate and was gathered in mid-2026 for a January 2028 sailing. Confirm current fares and rates at hollandamerica.com or with your travel agent
Brand promise	Independent. No display ads. No cruise-line affiliations. Soli Deo Gloria.
